A DISSERTATION IN FILM AND PHILOSOPHY



Occupation, Casting, and Cathexis in the Cinema of Roman Polanski

Toward a Tenurial Ontology

SEPTEMBER 2026

OCCUPATION · CASTING · CATHEXIS

Wohnen heißt Spuren hinterlassen.

To dwell means to leave traces.

WALTER BENJAMIN, 1935

"The land shall not be sold for ever: for the land is mine; for ye are strangers and sojourners with me."

LEVITICUS 25:23

Abstract

This dissertation offers a unified philosophical reading of the cinema of Roman Polanski, from the Łódź shorts of the late 1950s to *The Palace* (2023), organised around a single concept: *Besetzung*. The German noun designates at once military occupation, theatrical casting, and, in Freud's metapsychology, the libidinal investment of an object that James Strachey rendered as "cathexis." The dissertation argues that these are not three themes but one structure, operative at every level of the corpus: diegetic (the requisitioned apartment, the usurped throne, the occupied womb), dramaturgical (the role assigned before the self that plays it), and psychic (desire as a revocable lease on its object).

The three dominant critical paradigms, biographical-traumatic, absurdist-theatrical, and psychoanalytic-uncanny, each isolate one register of this structure. Against them, the dissertation reconstructs a *tenurial ontology*: an account of the human being as tenant rather than proprietor of its place, its role, and its desire, successor to a predecessor whose traces it inhabits and destined to be succeeded in turn. Chapter 1 traces the ontology's genealogy through the Polish absurd (Witkiewicz, Gombrowicz, Schulz, Mrożek, Różewicz, Kott) and the constellation of 1961–62, the years of the Eichmann trial and the Berlin Wall. Chapter 2 reads the Apartment Trilogy as a counter-Heideggerian phenomenology of the sublet. Chapter 3 recasts the chamber films as dramas of Derridean hostipitality in which host, guest, and hostage are positions within a single lease. Chapter 4 advances the formula that, in Polanski, *casting precedes existence*, drawing on Mauss, Gombrowicz, Althusser, Butler, and Deleuze's contractual theory of masochism. Chapter 5 turns to occupation in its historical sense (the Warsaw ghetto, the Dreyfus Affair, the Los Angeles water wars, Hardy's expiring leaseholds) and argues that *The Pianist* retroactively discloses the Holocaust as the lipogrammatic absence around which the earlier films were composed. Chapter 6 identifies a Gnostic cosmology in the occult films and the late hotel farce, in which the world itself is property held by a hostile landlord.

Chapter 7 formalises the argument in seven propositions, situates it within the speculative tradition from Kafka and Bulgakov to Lem, Abe, Ballard, Dick, Perec, Ishiguro, and Peele, and distinguishes two temporalities of tenure: the self-perpetuating loop of *tacit renewal* and the restitutive return of the Levitical *Jubilee*, of which the corpus contains exactly one instance. Read through Abraham and Torok's theory of the crypt, the loop proves to be the form of a history not yet mourned, and *The Pianist* the work of mourning that allows a lease to expire. The dissertation closes by turning its concept against the auteur: the ontology the films construct forecloses the proprietary claim to suffering by which their signatory, who in 1977 pleaded guilty to unlawful sexual intercourse with a thirteen-year-old girl and in 1978 fled the United States before sentencing, has sought to recast himself as a persecuted man.

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0

The Door Marked *Besetzt*

ARGUMENT

"Casting precedes existence."

IN THIS CHAPTER

0.1 A cinema without a doctrine
0.2 Three paradigms and their remainders
0.3 *Besetzung*: the argument
0.4 Method, corpus, and the tenancy of authorship
0.5 The author as tenant of his own name: a note on reading and culpability

0.1 A cinema without a doctrine

Polanski has published no philosophy. His interviews are studiously anti-theoretical, his autobiography, *Roman by Polanski* (1984), is anecdotal rather than reflective, and the films are overwhelmingly adaptations or collaborations: of Ira Levin, Roland Topor, Thomas Hardy, Shakespeare, Dickens, Ariel Dorfman, Arturo Pérez-Reverte, Władysław Szpilman, Robert Harris, Yasmina Reza, David Ives, Pascal Bruckner and Delphine de Vigan, and of screenplays co-written with Jerzy Skolimowski, Jakub Goldberg, Gérard Brach, Kenneth Tynan, John Brownjohn, Ronald Harwood and Olivier Assayas, among others. *Chinatown* (1974) is Robert Towne's script.

Yet across seven decades, four national industries, and nearly every genre from the absurdist short to the costume drama, the corpus returns, with an insistence that exceeds any single collaborator or declared intention, to a small repertoire of situations: a room one did not choose and cannot leave; a predecessor whose traces one inhabits; a neighbour, host, or state that assigns one a part; a desire that turns out to be on loan. This insistence is the dissertation's object. It is treated not as a set of recurring motifs, which would invite a catalogue, but as a grammar, which invites a theory.

0.2 Three paradigms and their remainders

Criticism has read this grammar in three principal ways, each correct about one register and blind to the others.

The *biographical-traumatic* paradigm reads the films through the director's life: a childhood in the Kraków ghetto, his mother's murder at Auschwitz, survival in hiding, the murder in 1969 of his wife Sharon Tate, eight and a half months pregnant, and four others by members of the Manson Family, and what the paradigm calls his exile after 1978, which was in fact flight from sentencing for a crime to which he had pleaded guilty. It explains the obstinacy of the motifs, but it fails chronologically as well as methodologically. The paranoid architecture of the Apartment Trilogy precedes the corpus's first direct treatment of the ghetto by nearly four decades, and *Knife in the Water* (1962), *Repulsion* (1965) and *Rosemary's Baby* (1968) all predate 1969. A paradigm that explains films by traumas they anticipate, or by traumas they decline to represent, has mistaken a structure for a symptom.

The *absurdist-theatrical* paradigm, grounded in Martin Esslin's *The Theatre of the Absurd* (1961), situates the films among Beckett, Ionesco, Pinter and their Polish counterparts, and rightly identifies the enclosure, repetition and black comedy they share. It dehistoricises, however. The metaphysical homelessness of the Absurd is universal and weightless;

Polanski's is juridical, spatial and contractual. It concerns leases, concierges, key money, requisitions, papers, and rent.

The *psychoanalytic-uncanny* paradigm, running from Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) through Julia Kristeva's abject to Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, is indispensable to the Apartment Trilogy, yet it interiorises what the films persistently externalise. The Polanskian uncanny is not the return of the subject's own repressed but the persistence of *someone else's* occupancy: the previous tenant's tooth in the wall, the sister's lover's razor on the basin, the dead woman's dresses in the wardrobe.

Each paradigm, this dissertation contends, sees one face of a single structure. The first sees occupation, the second casting, the third cathexis.

0.3 *Besetzung*: the argument

German affords the structure its name. *Besetzung* denotes, first, military occupation (*die Besetzung Polens*, 1939). Second, in theatre and film, it denotes the cast of a production and the act of casting, so that *Fehlbesetzung* means miscasting. Third, in Freud's metapsychology, it names the investment of psychic energy in an idea or object, which James Strachey rendered by the Greek coinage "cathexis," a choice Bruno Bettelheim later indicted as emblematic of the Standard Edition's estrangement of Freud's plain German. The participle *besetzt* is the word on an occupied lavatory door and an engaged telephone line. English "cast" supplies a serendipitous echo: the role, the plaster shell of the shattered body (the bandaged figure that closes *The Tenant*), the mould of a form, and the throw that Heidegger calls *Geworfenheit*, thrownness.

The thesis is that in Polanski these senses are not homonyms but one structure. To exist is to be *besetzt*: to occupy a place held before and after one by others, to be assigned a part one did not write, and to invest desire in objects held on revocable terms. The dissertation names the resulting philosophy a *tenurial ontology*, from *tenere*, to hold, the root of both "tenant" and "tenure."

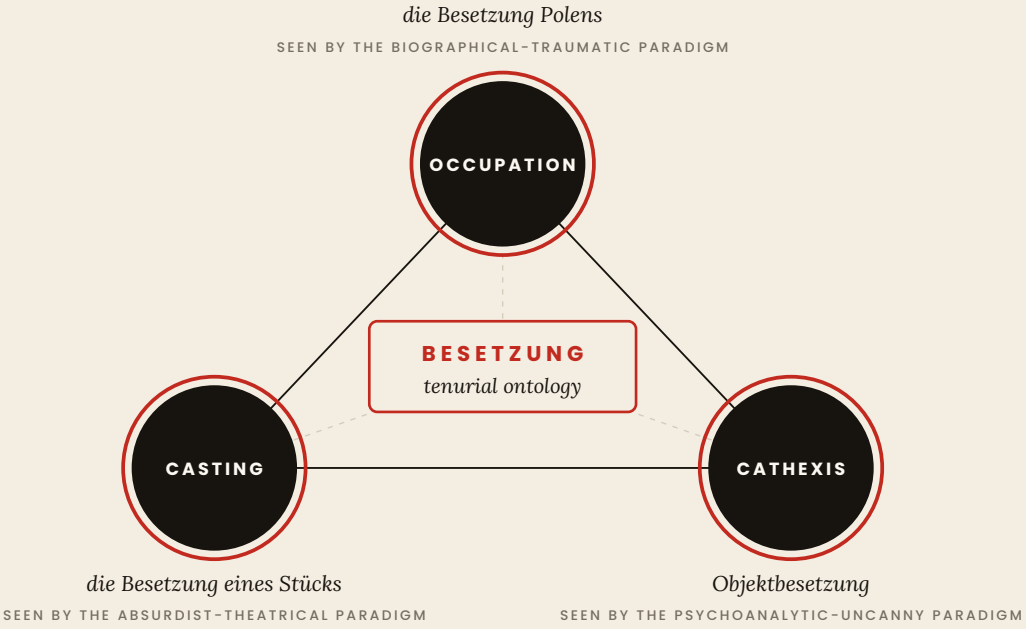


Fig. 1. *One structure, three registers. Each critical paradigm sees a single vertex of* Besetzung*; the dissertation reads the triangle whole.*

Its antagonist is Heidegger. For *Being and Time* (1927) authenticity is *Eigentlichkeit*, literally "ownedness," and death is Dasein's "ownmost" possibility. For Polanski's subjects nothing is ownmost, death included: they are constitutively un-owned, and they characteristically die a predecessor's death. Sartre held that existence precedes essence. The Polanskian correction, developed in Chapter 4, is that *casting precedes existence*.

0.4 Method, corpus, and the tenancy of authorship

The method is constellational in Walter Benjamin's sense. Films, philosophical texts and works of speculative fiction are read not as links in a positivist chain of influence but as elements whose juxtaposition makes legible a figure none of them contains alone. Where a debt is demonstrable (that of *Macbeth* to Jan Kott, of *The Tenant* to Roland Topor, of *Venus in Fur* to Leopold von Sacher-Masoch) it is documented; where the relation is structural rather than causal, the dissertation says so.

The corpus comprises the Łódź and early French shorts and the twenty-three features released between *Knife in the Water* and *The Palace*; unfinished and unrealised projects are excluded. Because the corpus is so largely adapted and co-written, the concept is applied reflexively to authorship itself. Polanski is treated not as proprietor of the œuvre but as its *signatory*. An adapter is a successor-occupant of another's text, and the films' recurrent fascination with ghostwriters,

forgers, understudies and substitute authors is read as the corpus's theory of its own production.

A second reflexive datum may be called *surrogate geography*. After 1978 the films repeatedly construct stand-ins for territories their director could not enter without risking arrest on the outstanding American warrant, the United States itself and countries likely to extradite him to it, Britain among them: a replica of Stonehenge built in France for *Tess* (1979), German coastline standing in for Martha's Vineyard in *The Ghost Writer* (2010), a Brooklyn apartment built in a Paris studio for *Carnage* (2011). The mode of production is itself tenurial, and its cause should be named exactly: not exile, but the avoidance of a sentence.

0.5 The author as tenant of his own name: a note on reading and culpability

No study of this corpus can pretend to innocence about its author. In March 1977, at Jack Nicholson's house in Los Angeles, Polanski, then forty-three, photographed a thirteen-year-old girl, Samantha Gailey (now Samantha Geimer, who has since told her own story in print), gave her champagne and part of a Quaalude, and raped her; she testified to a grand jury that she had told him no. He was indicted on six counts, among them rape by use of drugs, sodomy, and furnishing a controlled substance to a minor. Under a plea agreement he pleaded guilty to the lesser charge of unlawful sexual intercourse with a minor, and the remaining counts were dropped. In 1978, before sentencing, he fled the United States for France, and he has stayed beyond American jurisdiction since. Arrested in Zurich on the American warrant in 2009, he was freed when Switzerland refused extradition in 2010; a Polish court refused it in 2015.

Other women have since accused him. The British actress Charlotte Lewis said in 2010 that he sexually abused her in Paris in 1983, when she was sixteen. A woman first identified as Robin said in 2017 that he sexually assaulted her in 1973, when she was sixteen; the civil suit for rape she later brought was settled in 2024. The former actress Renate Langer said in 2017 that he raped her at his chalet in Gstaad in 1972, when she was fifteen. The artist Marianne Barnard said in 2017 that he sexually assaulted her during a photo shoot in 1975, when she was ten. The photographer Valentine Monnier said in 2019 that he beat and raped her at the same chalet in 1975, when she was eighteen. He denies every allegation. None has been tried in a criminal court, most lying beyond the statute of limitations, and in 2024 a Paris court acquitted him of defaming Lewis. The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences expelled him in 2018.

Two critical reflexes have dominated. The first, hagiographic, subordinates the biography to the œuvre, or annexes the director's real traumas as an interpretive key and thence as a moral alibi. The second, prosecutorial, reads the films as confession or symptom. This dissertation adopts neither, and its central concept is built so that it cannot serve as an alibi.

A tenurial ontology denies that any subject owns its suffering outright. It therefore disallows the move by which an author converts biographical injury into interpretive sovereignty over the work, or into exculpation. Chapter 5 turns this principle against the corpus's most notorious paratext, the director's assimilation of his situation to that of Alfred Dreyfus, which the argument names a *Fehlbesetzung* in a strict sense. The films are read as collaborative texts whose ideas exceed, and at points indict, their signatory.



1

Genealogy

The Polish Absurd and the Constellation of 1961–62

ARGUMENT

"The first role Polanski played was the one the occupation cast him in."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1.1 The first role
1.2 The Polish absurd: pills, masks, dummies, rafts
1.3 The shorts: a wardrobe, a goat, a sled
1.4 *Knife in the Water* (1962): the yacht as a floating lease
1.5 The constellation of 1961–62

1.1 The first role

Polanski was born in Paris in 1933; his family returned to Kraków in 1937, two years before the German invasion. The Germans deported his mother from the Kraków ghetto and murdered her at Auschwitz; his father, deported to Mauthausen, survived. The boy escaped the ghetto and survived the occupation in the countryside, sheltered by Polish Catholic families: a Jewish child passing as a Catholic, in a country where the Germans punished the hiding of Jews with death. After the war he worked as a child actor on stage and radio, appeared in Andrzej Wajda's *A Generation* (1955), and entered the Łódź Film School.

The biographical record matters here for one reason only, and it is not the one the traumatic paradigm supplies. It installs the triad of *Besetzung* as a lived structure before it becomes a cinematic one: a city under military occupation, survival by casting (a Jewish child made to play a Catholic one), and an existence held entirely at the discretion of hosts who risked their lives to keep him. The first role Polanski played was the one the occupation cast him in. What the corpus later generalises into an ontology was first a technique of survival, and the dissertation's closing argument turns on the difference between the two.

1.2 The Polish absurd: pills, masks, dummies, rafts

The corpus's intellectual inheritance is less the Parisian Absurd than its Polish precursor, which differs from Beckett's and Ionesco's in one decisive respect: its forms are imposed from outside, by others or by history.

Stanisław Ignacy Witkiewicz (Witkacy) supplies catastrophism and its central emblem. In *Insatiability* (1930) an Eastern invader pacifies the population with Murti-Bing pills that dissolve metaphysical anxiety, and Czesław Miłosz's *The Captive Mind* (1953) made the pill the emblem of the intellectual's capitulation to an occupying ideology. Witkacy thus furnishes the first figure of the *occupied mind*: cathexis administered by the occupier.

Witold Gombrowicz supplies the theory of casting. In *Ferdydurke* (1937) the self is a product of Form, pressed from outside by the "interhuman" sphere. Others make one a *gęba*, a mug or face, and can inflict *upupienie*, the humiliating reduction to a schoolboy's bottom. Identity is a mask manufactured by the gaze of others and worn under compulsion, which is precisely the condition of Polanski's tenants.

Bruno Schulz supplies the metaphysics of the role-bearer. In the "Treatise on Tailors' Dummies" in *Cinnamon Shops* (1934), the narrator's father preaches a heretical second creation in which matter, infinitely fecund and hungry for form, produces beings made for a single gesture or a single part. Schulz was shot dead in a Drohobycz street in November

1942 by Karl Günther, a Gestapo officer. His dummies, beings that are nothing but their role, are the ancestors of the mannequin-selves of *Repulsion* and *The Tenant*.

Sławomir Mrożek supplies the political parable of enclosure. In *Out at Sea* (1961) three castaways on a raft decide by electoral procedure which of them shall be eaten, so that democratic form sheathes the appropriation of a body. In *Striptease* (1961) two men in a room are stripped by a giant hand. Tadeusz Różewicz's *The Card Index* (1960) supplies the room without walls: its Hero lies in bed while figures from his life pass through his room as through a public thoroughfare, and the self is a filing card in someone else's register.

Jan Kott, finally, supplies the historical machine. *Shakespeare Our Contemporary* (1961; English 1964) reads the histories as a Grand Mechanism in which each usurper climbs the staircase of power only to be thrown down by the next, and pairs *King Lear* with Beckett's *Endgame*. History in Kott is a building whose tenants change and whose floor plan never does. Polanski's *Macbeth* (1971), analysed in Chapter 4, is its most literal cinematic realisation.

1.3 The shorts: a wardrobe, a goat, a sled

Two Men and a Wardrobe (1958) contains the corpus in one image. Two men emerge from the sea carrying a mirrored wardrobe, are turned away from the city's public spaces, witness its casual brutality, and return to the sea. The wardrobe is a room without a house, a dwelling carried rather than inhabited. Its mirror is the only surface in which the dispossessed can appear. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) is here displaced into exile: identity must be sought in a mirror one carries oneself, because no wall in the city will hold one. The film is the corpus's first statement of tenure without land.

The Fat and the Lean (1961) stages the master-servant relation that Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) bequeathed, via Alexandre Kojève's Paris lectures, to French thought. The lean servant, played by Polanski, glimpses the city on the horizon and is chained to a goat to keep him from it; when the master "liberates" him from the goat, he returns jubilant to service. The Hegelian servant achieves self-consciousness through labour. The Polanskian servant does not; he re-enacts Étienne de La Boétie's *Discourse on Voluntary Servitude* (c. 1552–53), in which domination endures because the dominated consent. His tenure in servitude is psychic before it is juridical: cathexis of the chain.

Mammals (1962) completes the triptych. Two men on a snowfield take turns hauling each other on a sled, each feigning injury to become the rider, until a third party makes off with the sled. The struggle for recognition becomes a struggle to be carried, the Hobbesian contest in its most economical form: every body seeks to occupy another's labour.

1.4 *Knife in the Water* (1962): the yacht as a floating lease

A married couple, Andrzej and Krystyna, pick up a young hitchhiker on their way to their yacht on the Masurian lakes and invite him aboard. The film has three actors, one hull, and one day and night. Its drama is a drama of occupancy: who has the right to be aboard, on what terms, and at whose pleasure.

Andrzej's hospitality is a demonstration of possession (car, yacht, wife) in a People's Republic that had officially abolished such distinctions, and the Party's cultural authorities received the film coolly. The boy is a guest who must work his passage, occupying the deck on sufferance. The knife he carries becomes the object of a mimetic triangle of exactly the kind René Girard theorised in *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel* (1961): Andrzej covets it because the boy possesses it, and covets the boy's youth because his wife might. The Hegelian struggle for recognition is conducted as seamanship, and Mrożek's raft reappears as a yacht: a polity of three, governed by whoever holds the tiller.

The ending is the corpus's first loop and its first act of casting. The boy goes overboard and hides; Krystyna finds him, and they sleep together aboard. At a fork in the road home, Andrzej must decide whether to believe the boy drowned, which casts him as a killer bound for the police station, or to believe his wife, which casts him as a cuckold. The car idles at the fork. Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) is inverted: the choice is between two roles, neither of which Andrzej authored, both assigned by another's testimony. *Casting precedes existence* is already present in nuce. Krzysztof Komeda's jazz score, the sound of a Westernised private sphere, plays over a subject who has discovered that his privacy was never his own.

1.5 The constellation of 1961–62

Knife in the Water was made in the years 1961–62, and the coincidence of what appeared around it is too dense to be accidental in Benjamin's sense, though it is not causal.

1961 was the year of the Eichmann trial in Jerusalem and of the Berlin Wall. It was the year of Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity*, with its phenomenology of the dwelling as the site of welcome; of Kott's *Shakespeare Our Contemporary*; of Stanisław Lem's *Solaris*, whose apparitions of the dead, installed in the living's quarters, the Polish text calls *goście*, "guests"; of Mrożek's *Out at Sea* and *Striptease*; of Esslin's *Theatre of the Absurd*; of Girard's first book; of Michel Foucault's *History of Madness*; and of Frantz Fanon's *The Wretched of the Earth*. 1962 added Buñuel's *The Exterminating Angel*, Welles's *The Trial*, Kōbō Abe's *The Woman in the Dunes*, Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle*, and the founding in Paris of the Panic Movement by Fernando Arrabal, Alejandro

Jodorowsky and Roland Topor, who would publish *Le Locataire chimérique* in 1964.

Across these texts the question of the human migrates from essence to occupancy. Who may cross the wall; who testifies for the vanished; who welcomes whom; who is confined with whom in a room, a pit, or a mansion that cannot be left; who is cast in which role by a mechanism, a court, or an occupying power. *Knife in the Water* is not influenced by this constellation. It belongs to it, as its first cinematic crystallisation along the tenurial axis: three people, one hull, no land.



2

The Apartment Trilogy

A Phenomenology of the Sublet

ARGUMENT

"To be a tenant is to find the traces of another."

IN THIS CHAPTER

2.1 Darmstadt answered from Kraków
2.2 *Repulsion*: the sub-tenant's body
2.3 *Rosemary's Baby*: the womb as leased premises
2.4 *The Tenant*: the ontology stated
2.5 Three laws of the sublet

2.1 Darmstadt answered from Kraków

In 1951, before an audience of architects at Darmstadt, amid Germany's postwar housing shortage, Heidegger delivered "Building Dwelling Thinking." The real plight of dwelling, he argued, is not the lack of houses but that mortals must ever again seek the essence of dwelling and learn to dwell. Dwelling is sparing and preserving; it gathers the fourfold of earth, sky, divinities and mortals.

The Apartment Trilogy (*Repulsion*, 1965; *Rosemary's Baby*, 1968; *The Tenant*, 1976) answers Darmstadt from Kraków. For these films the housing question *is* the ontological question. Their protagonists cannot learn to dwell because no dwelling is theirs: they are tenants, sub-tenants and successors, and what they meet in their rooms is not the fourfold but the previous occupant. Bulgakov had already stated the axiom. In *The Master and Margarita* (written 1928–40, published 1966–67), Woland remarks that the housing question has spoiled the Muscovites, and he says it from Apartment No. 50, the "bad apartment" whose tenants vanish one after another, a transparent figure for Stalinist arrests, until the devil's retinue moves in.

Walter Benjamin supplies the phenomenological key. In his 1935 exposé on Paris he writes *Wohnen heißt Spuren hinterlassen*, to dwell means to leave traces. The bourgeois interior is a casing for the private person, and the detective story is born from the pursuit of traces left there. The Polanskian corollary is exact: *to be a tenant is to find the traces of another*. Each film of the trilogy is a detective story in which the clue is the predecessor.

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) is thereby inverted. For Bachelard the house shelters daydreaming along a vertical axis from irrational cellar to rational attic. In the trilogy the vertical collapses into adjacency, into the neighbour's wall, and the apartment ceases to be a nest for reverie. It becomes an organism that dreams its tenant.

2.2 *Repulsion*: the sub-tenant's body

Carol, a Belgian manicurist in London, lives in her sister Hélène's South Kensington flat, a sub-tenant within a tenancy. The flat is saturated with another's occupancy: the razor and toothbrush of Hélène's lover in Carol's glass, and the lovers audible through the wall, so that others' desire arrives as acoustic intrusion.

When Hélène leaves on holiday, the flat decays around its remaining occupant. A skinned rabbit rots on a plate, potatoes sprout, cracks split the walls, and the walls themselves soften into flesh from which hands emerge to seize her. Two intruders breach the door. The suitor who breaks it down is killed with a candlestick. The landlord comes for the

rent, offers to waive it in exchange for sex, and tries to force himself on her; she kills him with the lover's razor.

That scene is the hinge of the trilogy. The landlord's assault makes explicit the premise of tenurial ontology, that the tenant's body is collateral, which the proprietor may try to seize. The weapon that answers him is itself a trace of another occupant, turned against the proprietor.

Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) names the rotting rabbit abject, the collapse of the border between self and not-self. What the tenurial reading adds is that the abject here belongs to the flat. The apartment has a body, and the tenant's own body turns out to be the last apartment. The soundscape (convent bells, nuns at play in the garden opposite, a dripping tap, a ticking clock) is the pressure of adjacent occupancies against a membrane that cannot hold.

The film ends as the camera travels to a family photograph and moves into the eye of the child Carol, whose fixed stare toward an older man in the photograph, often taken to be her father, critics have read as intimating that she was sexually abused as a child; the film never confirms it. The subject is absorbed into an image of prior occupancy, and if that reading is right, her body was occupied long before the flat. Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980) ends identically, closing on a 1921 photograph in which Jack Torrance stands among the Overlook's revellers, the caretaker who has always been the caretaker. In both films the subject was always already a tenant of the image.

The comparanda are instructive. In Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892), a woman under a rest cure is confined in a rented colonial mansion, a summer tenancy, until she frees and becomes the woman trapped behind the pattern. Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) had already made the house a body and the body a house. Darren Aronofsky's *Black Swan* (2010) inherits the trilogy whole: a performer cast in a double role, whose body is breached by the other she must play.

2.3 *Rosemary's Baby*: the womb as leased premises

The Woodhouses lease an apartment in the Bramford (the Dakota in exterior shots), vacated by the death of its elderly tenant, Mrs. Gardenia. She has left a note breaking with an unnamed "them" and a heavy secretary pushed against the linen closet; behind it, a passage leads to the neighbours' apartment. The predecessor has left a warning and a barricade. The new tenants remove both.

The Castevets' hospitality is predation, and neighbourly intimacy is the instrument of occupation: the coven is a co-op board of the damned. Guy, an actor, obtains a coveted role when his rival goes blind, casting by sacrifice, and he pays for it by agreeing that the coven may drug his wife

so that she can be raped and made to bear Satan's child. The Faustian pact, from Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* with its twenty-four-year term through Goethe to Thomas Mann's *Doctor Faustus* (1947), is revealed as what it always was, a lease. Rosemary's womb is sublet by her husband to the coven for the devil's tenancy, and the pregnancy becomes an occupation that Lucy Fischer's study of parturition and horror and Barbara Creed's account of the monstrous womb have taught criticism to read as the film's true subject.

Two formal features sharpen the argument. First, the anagram: Hutch's book reveals that Roman Castevet is Steven Marcato rearranged, identity as the re-occupation of the same letters by another name, the Scrabble tiles serving as an Oulipian machine of tenurial identity. The given name, inherited from Levin's novel, coincides with the director's; the coincidence is recorded here, not interpreted. Second, the withheld novum. Tzvetan Todorov's *The Fantastic* (1970) defines the genre as hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation, and the film sustains that hesitation, between prenatal paranoia and witchcraft, almost to the end. Even then it withholds the decisive image: the infant is never shown, only Rosemary's horror at what has been done to its eyes.

The film's most celebrated shot shows Minnie Castevet telephoning in a bedroom, visible only in part through a doorway. The half-open door, which governs what may be seen of another's quarters, is the trilogy's emblem. At the close the coven hails 1966 as the Year One, extending occupation to time itself, since a new calendar is a new lease on history. Rosemary begins to rock the cradle. The tenant ratifies the lease, and maternal cathexis is captured by the occupier.

The descendants are legion. Levin's own *The Stepford Wives* (1972) normalises replacement as suburban routine. Ari Aster's *Hereditary* (2018) restages the coven of neighbours and the body as vessel. Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) is the most rigorous heir: the Armitage family auctions Black bodies for occupation by white consciousness, and the Sunken Place makes racial and colonial the *Besetzung* that *Rosemary's Baby* renders marital.

2.4 *The Tenant*: the ontology stated

In *The Tenant* the ontology becomes explicit. Trelkovsky, played by Polanski, is a Polish-born clerk whose Frenchness is repeatedly interrogated. He rents an apartment whose previous tenant, Simone Choule, has thrown herself from its window and lies in hospital wrapped in bandages; when he visits her, she screams. He pays key money for the lease and submits to the landlord, Monsieur Zy, the concierge, and the house rules of silence and respectability. A petition circulates against a mother and her disabled daughter, and the building reveals its politics of expulsion. Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on

the exception; here the sovereign is the neighbour, who decides who counts as a proper tenant.

The traces multiply. Simone's dresses hang in the wardrobe. A tooth wrapped in cotton sits in a hole in the wall, Benjamin's trace literalised as relic. Hieroglyphs, echoing Simone's Egyptological interests, cover the lavatory wall: the undeciphered script of a prior civilisation, and a reminder that the Egyptian tomb is the archetypal dwelling built for its dead occupant. Across the courtyard, in the shared lavatory, Trelkovsky sees neighbours standing motionless for hours, and at last he sees himself.

The café serves him Simone's usual. The neighbours address him through her. He buys a wig, makes up his face, and wears her dress. Louis Althusser's "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970) holds that the subject is constituted when it turns in answer to a hail; *The Tenant* is the most exact dramatisation of interpellation in cinema, since the neighbours hail Trelkovsky as Simone until he turns and becomes her. In Judith Butler's terms, his drag is not transgression but compliance, a citation compelled by the building. At the climax the neighbours appear as a theatre audience applauding his fall from the window; he climbs back and jumps again. The courtyard is a stage, and casting is execution.

The film ends in a loop. Wrapped in a full-body plaster cast in the hospital bed, Trelkovsky sees himself and Stella arriving to visit, and he screams Simone's scream. The tenant has become the predecessor, and his former self is now the visitor.

Roland Topor's *Le Locataire chimérique* (1964) supplies the plot and, through the Panic Movement, a poetics of terror as farce. The film's philosophical company is larger. Kafka's *The Metamorphosis* (1915) installs three lodgers who take over the Samsa household while Gregor's room becomes a junk store, and "The Burrow" is haunted by an unlocatable noise. Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) and Gogol's "Diary of a Madman" (1835) supply the clerk displaced into a role. Ingmar Bergman's *Persona* (1966) stages the transfer of identity between two women, and Bergman's cinematographer Sven Nykvist shot *The Tenant*.

Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954) is reversed: the watcher of the courtyard becomes its watched. Sartre's *Being and Nothingness* (1943) supplies the voyeur at the keyhole, surprised by footsteps and fixed in shame by the look. Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975), published the year before the film, supplies panopticism, though Polanski's neighbours do not merely watch; they cast. J.G. Ballard's *High-Rise* (1975) renders the apartment block as a state of nature, and Georges Perec's *Life: A User's Manual* (1978) opens the Parisian building in cross-section. Among them, *The Tenant* is the work in which the director cast himself as the man whom others cast.

2.5 Three laws of the sublet

The trilogy yields three laws.

I. **The law of the predecessor-trace.** Every apartment is haunted, not by ghosts but by tenancy. Something of the previous occupant (a tooth, a note, a razor, a dress) persists, and it persists as an instruction.

II. **The law of the neighbour-sovereign.** Sovereignty in the building belongs to those adjacent, who decide on the exception and enforce it through noise complaints, petitions and hospitality.

III. **The law of the last apartment.** When the walls fail, occupation moves inward, from Carol's walls to Rosemary's womb to Trelkovsky's plaster cast. The body is the final premises, and it too is sublet.



3

Hostipitality

Host, Guest, Hostage

ARGUMENT

"What is exchanged in hospitality is never ownership, only tenure."

IN THIS CHAPTER

3.1 The grammar of welcome
3.2 *Cul-de-sac* (1966): the castle and the tide
3.3 *The Fearless Vampire Killers* (1967): the invitation
3.4 *What?* (1972): the undressed guest
3.5 *Death and the Maiden* (1994): the torturer as guest
3.6 *Carnage* (2011): the parlour as state of nature
3.7 One lease, three positions

3.1 The grammar of welcome

Émile Benveniste's *Indo-European Language and Society* (1969) reconstructs the Latin *hostis* as the stranger bound to one by reciprocal obligation before it hardened into "enemy," and reads *hospes*, host, as containing *potis*, mastery: the host is master of the guest. The same Latin lexicon supplies *hostia*, the sacrificial victim, whence the Eucharistic Host, and modern biology adds the host organism that harbours a parasite. Every sense will be needed.

Kant's *Toward Perpetual Peace* (1795) limits cosmopolitan right to universal hospitality: the stranger's right not to be treated with hostility on arrival. This is a right of visit (*Besuchsrecht*), not a right to be a guest (*Gastrecht*), which requires a separate contract. Modern hospitality is thus founded on the distinction between visiting and residing, and Polanski's figures live in its gap, admitted but never entitled to stay.

Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) makes the dwelling the precondition of welcome; *Otherwise than Being* (1974) radicalises welcome into *substitution*, the subject as hostage of the Other, one-for-the-other. Derrida's *Of Hospitality* (1997) and "Hostipitality" (2000) show that the conditional laws of hospitality can never coincide with its unconditional law, and that the host is always on the way to becoming the hostage.

The chapter's claim is that in Polanski host, guest and hostage are not distinct persons but successive positions within a single lease. Levinas's ethical substitution appears in the corpus as literal substitution, and every film of hospitality ends in a reversal of occupancy.

3.2 *Cul-de-sac* (1966): the castle and the tide

George, a retired businessman, and his young wife Teresa live in a castle on Holy Island, Lindisfarne, cut off twice daily by the tide, so that proprietorship itself is held on nature's lease. Two wounded gangsters arrive. Richard occupies the castle and waits for his boss, Mr. Katelbach, who never comes: Beckett's Godot relocated to a Northumbrian causeway. His dying accomplice is played by Jack MacGowran, among the foremost Beckett interpreters of his generation, who would also play Professor Abronsius in *The Fearless Vampire Killers*. The corpus's link to Beckett is embodied, not merely allusive.

The proprietors become hostages. When bourgeois visitors arrive, the occupier is recast as the household's butler, and George, dressed by his wife in her nightgown and made up, becomes the corpus's first Penthean figure (Chapter 4).

Harold Pinter's early plays supply the film's grammar, and Irving Wardle's phrase "comedy of menace" fits it exactly. In *The Room* (1957) a woman learns from strangers that the room she occupies has been

advertised as vacant, the purest statement of tenurial ontology in the modern theatre: one's occupancy is already another's vacancy. In *The Birthday Party* (1958) two sinister visitors break the lone lodger of a seaside boarding house. In *The Caretaker* (1960) a tramp invited into a room contests its tenure, while his identity papers remain forever elsewhere, in Sidcup. *Cul-de-sac* transposes all three to a castle.

At the end Richard is dead, Teresa has left with a visitor, and George sits alone on a rock in the rising tide, calling for his first wife. The proprietor has become the tenant of a rock, awaiting a predecessor who will not return. Kōbō Abe's *The Woman in the Dunes* (1962) offers the counter-image: an entomologist lodged in a house at the bottom of a sand pit, compelled to dig, who, when escape is finally possible, stays, while the world outside files him as missing. The tenancy is completed as vocation, and the self is legally replaced by its own absence.

3.3 *The Fearless Vampire Killers* (1967): the invitation

The vampire is the theological figure of hostipitality. Folklore forbids him to cross a threshold uninvited, and Stoker's Count receives Jonathan Harker with the words "Welcome to my house! Enter freely and of your own will!" (*Dracula*, 1897). Polanski's Professor Abronsius, whom the narration associates with the University of Königsberg, which was Kant's, enters Count von Krolock's castle as a guest with his assistant Alfred, played by Polanski. The Enlightenment has accepted the vampire's hospitality.

Two scenes carry the argument. At the vampires' ball the dancers pass before a great mirror in which only the living intruders appear. Lacan's mirror stage is inverted: reflection exposes not the ego's unity but its anomaly, the living as uninvited guests among a reflectionless community. Earlier, the Jewish innkeeper Shagal, newly a vampire, laughs off a crucifix brandished at him, because he is the wrong vampire for that theology. The joke rebounds on the blood libel, the antisemitic slander that Jews murder Christians for their blood, returned as farce by a Jewish director who had survived the genocide such slanders helped prepare.

The ending completes the dialectic. The narrator informs us that Abronsius, fleeing Transylvania, did not know he was carrying away the very evil he had meant to destroy, as Sarah, now a vampire, bites Alfred in the sleigh. The exterminator becomes the vector, and the host becomes a host in the epidemiological sense. Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947), in which enlightenment reverts to myth, receives its most compact cinematic gloss: the rationalist carries the plague into the world.

3.4 *What?* (1972): the undressed guest

An American hitchhiker, escaping men who try to rape her after giving her a lift, takes refuge in an Italian villa of eccentrics and loses her clothes piece by piece, a picaresque of the guest as object that crosses Lewis Carroll's *Alice* with Sade. Marcello Mastroianni's retired pimp, who craves the whip, anticipates *Venus in Fur* by four decades. The film is slight, but its logic is strict: the guest owns not even her garments, and each is a lease revoked. The refuge repeats, as farce, the appropriation she fled.

3.5 *Death and the Maiden* (1994): the torturer as guest

In an unnamed South American country emerging from dictatorship, a lawyer newly appointed to a truth commission brings home a stranger who helped him with a flat tyre. His wife, Paulina, believes she recognises the voice of the doctor who, years before, raped and tortured her while playing Schubert's String Quartet in D minor, D. 810, *Death and the Maiden*. She takes him hostage and tries him in her living room. Hospitality becomes hostage-taking, and the home becomes a court.

Jean Améry's essay "Torture," in *At the Mind's Limits* (1966), supplies the philosophical core. With the first blow the victim loses trust in the world, and whoever was tortured remains tortured, unable to feel at home in the world again. Torture is *Besetzung* absolute, the occupation of a body by another's will, and Paulina's house has not been hers since. The Schubert deepens the figure. In Matthias Claudius's poem, which Schubert set in 1817, Death tells the maiden that he comes as a friend, not to punish. The torturer's use of the music is an occupation of the maiden's voice by death.

The film's evidence is voice, smell and turns of phrase, and Paulina's certainty cannot be verified: Todorov's hesitation is transposed from genre to justice. Ariel Dorfman's play (1991) is explicit that the commission's mandate extends only to cases ending in death, so that survivors fall outside its jurisdiction. The final scene, at a concert, shows Paulina and the doctor exchanging glances across the auditorium. Victim and perpetrator have become co-tenants of the post-dictatorial state, and the society of transition is a building shared with one's torturers. Primo Levi's grey zone is here not a zone but a floor plan.

3.6 *Carnage* (2011): the parlour as state of nature

Adapted with Yasmina Reza from her play *Le Dieu du carnage* (2006), the film brings two couples together in a Brooklyn apartment to settle, civilly, a playground fight in which one couple's son struck the other's with a stick, breaking two teeth. Teeth again: the corpus's recurring relic,

from Simone Choule's wall to this parlour, marks violence displaced from its origin.

The guests cannot leave. They reach the elevator repeatedly and return, as the dinner guests of Buñuel's *The Exterminating Angel* (1962) cannot cross the threshold of the salon. Edward Albee's *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* (1962) had made hospitality a ritual combat, and Sartre's *No Exit* (1944) had furnished the room without an exit in which hell is other people.

The philosophical stakes are Hobbesian. The lawyer, who defends a pharmaceutical company against evidence of concealed side effects, professes faith in the "god of carnage"; the hostess, who is writing a book on Darfur, professes humanitarian civility. Norbert Elias's *The Civilizing Process* (1939) runs backwards in real time. The abject returns to the bourgeois interior when a guest vomits over the hostess's prized art books, and the lawyer's telephone, umbilicus to his client, is drowned in a vase of tulips. The family hamster, released onto the street before the film begins, is the domestic animal expelled from tenancy.

The final shot shows the two boys reconciled in the park and the hamster alive. The adults' carnage was a displaced representation, the parents cast as proxies in a war their children had already concluded. The Brooklyn of the film was built in Paris.

3.7 One lease, three positions

Across these films the positions rotate with mechanical regularity. The host becomes hostage (*Cul-de-sac*, *Death and the Maiden*), the guest becomes occupier (*Cul-de-sac*, *Rosemary's Baby*), the guest becomes victim (*The Fearless Vampire Killers*, *What?*), and the host-guest distinction dissolves into a shared captivity (*Carnage*). Derrida's hostipitality is the corpus's rule rather than its exception: the conditional law of hospitality always already contains its reversal, because what is exchanged in hospitality is never ownership, only tenure.



4

Casting Precedes Existence

ARGUMENT

"The god of casting punishes the man who wants to own his role."

IN THIS CHAPTER

4.1 From essence to role
4.2 *Macbeth* (1971): the throne as role
4.3 *Venus in Fur* (2013): the audition as contract
4.4 *The Ghost Writer* (2010): the substitute author
4.5 *Based on a True Story* (2017): the double who writes
4.6 *Bitter Moon* (1992): narration as contract
4.7 The self on lease

4.1 From essence to role

In *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946) Sartre held that existence precedes essence: the human being first exists and only then defines itself. Polanski's films reverse the order without restoring essence. Before a subject exists as a self, it has already been assigned a part.

Marcel Mauss's lecture "A Category of the Human Mind: The Notion of Person; the Notion of Self" (1938) traces the person from the ancestral mask and name assigned to a role in the clan, through the Roman legal *persona*, to the late moral self. Polanski runs Mauss backwards: the self regresses to the mask. Gombrowicz's Form and *gęba* (Chapter 1) supply the mechanism, Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956) the sociology of front stage and back, Althusser the hail, and Butler the citation. The theatrical tradition supplies the scenes. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921) and *Henry IV* (1922) present characters without authors and a man who lives as the emperor he once played. Genet's *The Maids* (1947) and *The Balcony* (1956) stage domination as costume and ritual.

Polanski's own screen appearances distribute the signatory across every position of the lease: the servant of *The Fat and the Lean*, the hapless assistant of *The Fearless Vampire Killers*, the hoodlum who slits the detective's nostril in *Chinatown*, the tenant of *The Tenant*. Servant, victim, violator: the author casts himself in each role and owns none. The formula follows. *Casting precedes existence*: one is assigned a part before one exists as the one who plays it, and the self is the residue of its roles, not their source.

4.2 *Macbeth* (1971): the throne as role

Adapted with Kenneth Tynan and financed by Playboy Productions, *Macbeth* is the corpus's most literal realisation of Jan Kott's reading in "Macbeth or Death-Infected." The witches are casting agents. They hail Macbeth by a title he does not yet hold, "All hail, Macbeth, that shalt be king hereafter!", and prophecy becomes interpellation. Usurpation is occupation of a role vacated by murder, and the crown is *Besetzung* in its purest form: a part that outlives each occupant and is passed on by killing. Macbeth's own verdict, that life is "a poor player / That struts and frets his hour upon the stage / And then is heard no more," defines existence as bad acting on a lease of one hour.

Polanski and Tynan added a coda. After Macbeth's death, Donalbain, the dead king's younger son, rides to the witches' lair, and the succession resumes. Kott's staircase has no top floor. Critics have long read the film's unsparing violence in light of the murders of August 1969, in which members of the Manson Family, Charles Watson, Susan Atkins and Patricia Krenwinkel, acting on Charles Manson's orders, killed Sharon

Tate, eight and a half months pregnant, and four others at the house she and Polanski rented on Cielo Drive; this dissertation records that reading and declines it as a key, for the reason given in section 0.2.

4.3 *Venus in Fur* (2013): the audition as contract

At the end of a day of fruitless auditions for his adaptation of Leopold von Sacher-Masoch's *Venus in Furs* (1870), a playwright-director, Thomas, is surprised by a latecomer, Vanda, apparently vulgar and unprepared, who proceeds to take over the audition, the script and the director. Adapted with David Ives from his play (2010), the film casts Mathieu Amalric, whose resemblance to Polanski has been widely noted, as Thomas, and Emmanuelle Seigner, Polanski's wife, as Vanda. The director's surrogate plays the man whom the actress he is auditioning strips of authorship.

Gilles Deleuze's *Coldness and Cruelty* (1967) supplies the decisive distinction. Masochism is not sadism's complement. It is contractual, persuasive and pedagogical: the masochist educates the woman into the torturer and binds her by contract, as Sacher-Masoch's Severin binds Wanda. Its humour subverts the law by obeying it with excessive literalness, and its temporality is suspense. Sadism, by contrast, is institutional, demonstrative and ironic.

The distinction organises the whole corpus. The lease is a Masochian contract: the tenant pays key money and signs away his noise, his visitors and his habits, contracting his own subjection. Trelkovsky's comedy is Deleuzian humour, obedience to the letter of the house rules until they consume the one who obeys. The corpus's institutions (the ghetto, the army, the coven, the state) are Sadean. Polanski's cinema oscillates between Masochian contracts (lease, marriage, audition, the Faustian pact) and Sadean institutions, and it is most itself where a contract turns out to have been an institution all along.

The ending completes the reversal. Thomas, dressed in women's clothing, is bound to a prop cactus left on the stage by a previous production, while Vanda, in furs, dances like a maenad. Critics routinely gloss the scene through Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE), in which Pentheus, the king who denies Dionysus, is persuaded by the god to dress as a woman to spy on the maenads and is torn apart by them. The corpus has repeated this punishment for forty-seven years: George in *Cul-de-sac* (1966), Trelkovsky in *The Tenant* (1976), Thomas in *Venus in Fur* (2013). Each victim is a proprietor, of a castle, a lease, a text, and each is forced into the feminine role and dispossessed. The *Penthean cycle* is the tenurial ontology's revenge on ownership, and it is apt that its avenger is Dionysus, god of the theatre: the god of casting punishes the man who wants to own his role.

4.4 *The Ghost Writer* (2010): the substitute author

A professional ghostwriter, never named, is hired to complete the memoirs of the former British prime minister Adam Lang, a transparent analogue of Tony Blair, after his predecessor on the job, Lang's aide McAra, has drowned. Adapted with Robert Harris from his novel *The Ghost* (2007), the film is the corpus's most sustained allegory of succession.

The Ghost inherits McAra's manuscript, his room in Lang's island house, his clothes, and his car. The car's satellite navigation, still programmed with McAra's last journey, leads the Ghost to the house of a Harvard professor who, it transpires, recruited Lang's wife for the CIA. The dead predecessor literally drives the successor. The secret is cryptonymic: the first words of the manuscript's chapters, read in sequence, disclose the recruitment. At the book launch the Ghost sends the discovery to Lang's widow in a note passed hand to hand, and he leaves. Offscreen, a car strikes him, and the manuscript's pages scatter across the street. He dies the predecessor's death, as Trelkovsky did.

Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) is here literalised: the author's death scatters the text. Michel Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) describes the author-function as a juridical and commercial principle of attribution, and the statesman's memoir is exactly such a function, written by a ghost and signed by a man who did not write it. Borges's "Pierre Menard, Author of the *Quixote*" (1939) had already defined authorship as the re-occupation of an existing text.

The film's surrogate geography and its conditions of completion close the circle. Its Martha's Vineyard is German coastline, because its director could not enter the United States without arrest, and its post-production was completed after he was arrested in Zurich in September 2009 on the 1978 warrant, while he was held in Swiss custody and then under house arrest in Gstaad pending a decision on his extradition, which Switzerland refused in 2010. The Ghost's island fortress is *Cul-de-sac*'s castle, updated. The detention invites the pun that the signatory was *besetzt*, and the pun should be refused: he was not occupied but held on a warrant for a sentence he had fled.

4.5 *Based on a True Story* (2017): the double who writes

A novelist, Delphine, blocked after the success of a book about her mother, is befriended by a ghostwriter known as Elle, who insinuates herself into Delphine's home and life and proposes to write in her place. Adapted with Olivier Assayas from Delphine de Vigan's novel (2015), the film leaves open whether Elle is a person or a projection, the book Delphine will write, a double who occupies the author from within. Stephen King's *Misery* (1987) holds the author captive to the reader who

would dictate his text, and *The Dark Half* (1989) lets a pseudonym murder its writer. Polanski's film adds only a quiet corollary: the author's most intimate occupier may be her own next book. The motif anticipates the "autoforgery" examined in Chapter 5, the self as forger of itself.

4.6 *Bitter Moon* (1992): narration as contract

On a cruise ship bound for Istanbul, a staid English couple meet a paraplegic American writer, Oscar, and his young wife, Mimi. Oscar compels the husband, Nigel, to listen, instalment by instalment, to the history of his erotic and sadomasochistic relationship with Mimi. The film adapts Pascal Bruckner's *Lunes de fiel* (1981).

Scheherazade is inverted. Oscar narrates not to postpone his death but to bind his auditor, each instalment a further clause of a Masochian contract, and Nigel pays in attention and desire until he has become a character in the story he was only meant to hear. Georges Bataille's *Erotism* (1957) makes transgression the condition of the erotic; here transgression is the narrative contract itself. The voyage ends at the New Year's Eve party, when the lease on the year expires: Oscar shoots Mimi and then himself, and the English couple survive, their ownership of their own marriage undone.

4.7 The self on lease

The chapter's cases converge on a single proposition. Role is prior to self, and the role is held on lease: auditioned, prophesied, ghostwritten, narrated, assigned by neighbours or bought, as Guy Woodhouse buys his part in *Rosemary's Baby* by delivering his drugged wife to be raped. The Penthean cycle punishes those who mistake a role for property. The Masochian contract names the form in which the corpus's subjects consent to their tenure, and the Sadean institution names the form in which tenure is imposed. The next chapter turns from the contract to the institution, and from the stage to history.



5

Occupation Proper

History, Land, and the Lipogram

ARGUMENT

"*History, unlike ontology, has an exit.*"

IN THIS CHAPTER

5.1 The lipogram
5.2 *The Pianist* (2002): the key to the building
5.3 *J'accuse* (2019): the text in search of an author
5.4 *Chinatown* (1974): proprietorship by proxy
5.5 *Tess* (1979): the expiring leasehold
5.6 *Oliver Twist* (2005): the unhoused child
5.7 *Pirates* (1986) and *Frantic* (1988): furniture and baggage
5.8 History and its exit

5.1 The lipogram

Georges Perec, born in Paris in 1936 to Polish-Jewish parents, lost his father, a volunteer in the French army, to his wounds in June 1940; his mother was deported from Drancy in 1943 and murdered at Auschwitz. *La Disparition* (1969) is a novel of some three hundred pages written without the letter *e*, a detective story about a disappearance whose true object is the missing letter itself, which critics have read as *eux*, "them." *W, or the Memory of Childhood* (1975) alternates fragments of memory with a fiction of an island whose Olympic society is gradually revealed as a camp. Perec's is a speculative fiction whose novum is historical. The editors of *Cahiers du cinéma*, in their 1970 reading of John Ford's *Young Mr. Lincoln*, named the same operation a structuring absence.

Until 2002 the Holocaust is the lipogrammatic letter of Polanski's cinema. Everything it structures is present: the denouncing neighbour, the enforced silence, the hiding room, the assumed identity, the requisitioned apartment, the predecessor who vanished. Only the ghetto itself is absent. *The Pianist* restores the letter, and in restoring it decodes the corpus.

5.2 *The Pianist* (2002): the key to the building

The film adapts, in Ronald Harwood's screenplay, the memoir of Władysław Szpilman, a pianist at Polish Radio, first published in a censored edition in 1946 and republished in 1998. It is set in Warsaw rather than Kraków, so that even the director's most personal film makes its history as the tenant of another's testimony. It opens in September 1939, as Szpilman plays Chopin's Nocturne in C-sharp minor at Polish Radio and German bombs strike the building.

Occupation then unfolds as literal sequence, each step imposed by the German authorities: armbands, a ghetto wall built before the family's eyes, forced relocation into apartments vacated by others, deportation from the Umschlagplatz. At the train, a Jewish policeman pulls Szpilman from the line, and Primo Levi's grey zone, theorised in *The Drowned and the Saved* (1986), acquires a face. The Germans deport his parents, his brother and his sisters to Treblinka, where they are murdered, and he survives by someone else's decision.

The hiding apartments arranged by friends in the Polish underground contain the whole Apartment Trilogy with its metaphysics removed. The tenant must not exist. Silence is the condition of survival, so that the noise complaints of *The Tenant* are decoded as a matter of life and death. In one flat stands a piano he may not play, and over its keys he mimes a performance: music as pure cathexis, without sound. When a neighbour discovers him and screams, the neighbour-sovereign stands revealed in the historical register, as the power to denounce.

Through his windows Szpilman watches the Ghetto Uprising of 1943 and the Warsaw Uprising of 1944, and the tenant's view becomes testimony. Giorgio Agamben's *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998) describes the witness as a remnant who testifies for those who cannot, his testimony constituted by what it lacks. After the Uprising's defeat Szpilman inhabits the ruins of a city itself evicted. In the attic of a ruined house he is found by a German officer, Wilm Hosenfeld, and asked what he is. He answers that he is a pianist and plays, in the film, Chopin's G-minor Ballade. Bachelard's attic, room of reverie, becomes a room of survival. Hosenfeld hides and feeds him and leaves him his greatcoat; Hosenfeld himself died in Soviet captivity in 1952.

The greatcoat completes the chapter's argument. When Polish troops arrive, Szpilman, wearing the German coat, is nearly shot as a German: the costume of the occupier almost kills the occupied. Casting under occupation is mortal. After the war Szpilman returns to the rebuilt studios of Polish Radio and plays the Nocturne in C-sharp minor, the piece the bombs interrupted in 1939. Chapter 7 will argue that this resumption is the only Jubilee in the corpus.

The film's aesthetic is passivity. Szpilman is neither hero nor resister; he survives through luck, hiding and others' help. The film refuses the redemptive agency of *Schindler's List* (1993) and stands closer to the ethic of Claude Lanzmann's *Shoah* (1985). Adorno's early dictum that to write poetry after Auschwitz is barbaric was revised in *Negative Dialectics* (1966), which grants perennial suffering as much right to expression as a tortured man has to scream. The scream that ends *The Tenant* is thereby legitimated in retrospect. It was the lipogram's only audible sound.

5.3 *J'accuse* (2019): the text in search of an author

Released in English as *An Officer and a Spy* and adapted with Robert Harris from his novel of that title (2013), the film follows Georges Picquart, who in 1895 succeeds the ailing Jean Sandherr as head of the army's Statistical Section and inherits its archive. The predecessor-trace becomes a state archive, and what it contains is forgery.

The Affair is a problem of attribution. The *bordereau*, an unsigned memorandum retrieved from the German embassy, is a text in search of an author. Alfred Dreyfus, a Jewish artillery officer, is cast as its author, while the true author is Esterhazy: the army needs a Jew to play the traitor. Alphonse Bertillon, pioneer of criminal anthropometry, testified that the very dissimilarity between Dreyfus's hand and the *bordereau* proved his guilt, because Dreyfus had forged his own handwriting, a theory of "autoforgery." The film casts Mathieu Amalric, the Thomas of *Venus in Fur*, as Bertillon. The corpus's surrogate for the author plays the expert who proves that a man wrote a text he did not write. Major

Henry's forgeries and his suicide in 1898 complete the archive's corruption.

The degradation of 5 January 1895, in the courtyard of the École Militaire, is a ceremony of un-casting: insignia torn away, sword broken, costume stripped before a crowd. Devil's Island, a hut within a palisade, is the minimal tenancy. Hannah Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) called the Affair a kind of dress rehearsal for the twentieth century, a theatrical metaphor the concept of *Besetzung* takes literally. Girard's *The Scapegoat* (1982) describes the community that restores its unanimity by expelling a victim cast as guilty, and Zola's open letter in *L'Aurore* of 13 January 1898 restores authorship as accusation by naming the true authors of the injustice.

The film ends years later, after Dreyfus's rehabilitation in 1906. Dreyfus calls on Picquart, now Minister of War, to ask that his years of imprisonment count toward his seniority, and Picquart refuses. Restitution is denied; there is no Jubilee.

The *Fehlbesetzung*. The film's release was accompanied by remarks from its director, in an interview published with its press materials, drawing a parallel between the machinery of persecution the film depicts and his own treatment. They provoked widespread condemnation, sharpened when, days before the French release in November 2019, Valentine Monnier published her accusation that he had raped her in 1975, which he denies. At the César ceremony of February 2020, where he won the prize for best director in absentia, the actress Adèle Haenel walked out in protest.

The tenurial ontology forbids the analogy on its own terms. Dreyfus was cast as the author of a text he did not write; the structure of his case is false attribution, and its remedy is restitution. The director's case concerns his rape of a thirteen-year-old girl, which he admitted in a guilty plea to unlawful sexual intercourse with a minor before fleeing sentencing. Dreyfus served more than four years on Devil's Island for a crime he did not commit; Polanski admitted a crime and evaded its sentence. The analogy therefore mistakes the structure. It is a *Fehlbesetzung* in the strict sense, the casting of oneself in a role one does not fit. It is also the single proprietary gesture in a corpus that otherwise forbids proprietorship: the claim to own the role of the persecuted. The films know better than their signatory. In *J'accuse* itself, persecution is precisely not a possession but a part imposed by others, which is why it cannot be claimed.

5.4 *Chinatown* (1974): proprietorship by proxy

In Los Angeles in 1937, water is the medium of land occupation. The city's water engineer, Hollis Mulwray, whose name echoes William Mulholland, builder of the Los Angeles Aqueduct (1913) that drained the Owens Valley, is found drowned in a drought. The detective Jake Gittes discovers that water is being dumped at night to drive down the price of the Northwest Valley, which is being bought up for annexation and irrigation. The purchases have been made in the names of residents of a rest home, some of them recently dead. This is proprietorship by proxy, the predecessor-trace inverted: the dead are occupied as fronts.

The legal backdrop is the Western doctrine of prior appropriation, first in time, first in right, which founds water rights on prior occupancy and makes tenurial ontology a matter of statute. Rousseau's *Discourse on Inequality* (1755) located the origin of civil society in the first man who enclosed a plot of ground, thought of saying "this is mine," and found people simple enough to believe him; *Chinatown* is that sentence rendered as noir. Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689), which justified appropriation by labour and declared that in the beginning all the world was America, and C.B. Macpherson's *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism* (1962) supply the genealogy of the proprietor.

Noah Cross is the proprietor absolute. He owns the water, is buying the valley, and, it emerges, has raped his daughter Evelyn and fathered her child, whom he now seeks to possess. Genealogy becomes occupation, the owner of the future claiming the bodies of his descendants. The eye is the film's figure for knowledge: the flaw in Evelyn's iris, the taillight Jake breaks to follow her car, the bifocals in the salt pond, and the final shot through her eye. Jake's slit nostril, inflicted by a hoodlum played by the director, is the signatory's mark on his protagonist's body.

Chinatown itself is the district where, in Jake's past, an attempt to protect someone ensured that she was hurt, and the Orientalist figure, in Edward Said's sense, of a place where one cannot know what is happening. The film both criticises and depends on that figure. Polanski insisted on the catastrophic ending over Towne's less tragic draft, and the ending returns Jake to Chinatown to repeat his past: tacit renewal. Marc Reisner's *Cadillac Desert* (1986) and Mike Davis's *City of Quartz* (1990) supply the history; David Lynch's *Mulholland Drive* (2001), named for the road that bears the aqueduct builder's name, supplies the heir.

5.5 *Tess* (1979): the expiring leasehold

Shot in France, with a replica of Stonehenge, because its director could not risk extradition from Britain, and dedicated "To Sharon," *Tess* adapts Hardy's novel of 1891, which is a treatise on tenure. John Durbeyfield

learns that he descends from the ancient d'Urbervilles, but the "d'Urbervilles" to whom Tess is sent are the Stokes, a merchant family who acquired the name: lineage as a property let to the highest bidder. The son of the house, Alec, who bears the purchased name, takes possession of Tess as well: he rapes her in the Chase, an ancient wood near the estate. Hardy's narration withholds the act, which was long discussed as a seduction, though Hardy has Alec find her asleep and subtitles the novel "A Pure Woman." In the novel the Durbeyfields' cottage is held on a lease for lives, which expires with John's death; the family is evicted and ends by camping beside the d'Urberville tombs, the heirs of an ancient house dwelling among their ancestors' vaults.

Years later, when Angel Clare returns to find her living with Alec, to whom her family's destitution has driven her, Tess kills Alec. She spends her last free night on the altar stone at Stonehenge, the oldest ritual dwelling in Britain serving as the last shelter of the dispossessed; she is arrested there, and the novel ends with her hanging. The sacrifice, the *hostia*, is completed by the state. Hardy's verdict, that "the President of the Immortals, in Æschylean phrase, had ended his sport with Tess," joins Schopenhauer's blind Will, which Hardy's later Immanent Will inherits, to a cosmos run by an absentee landlord. Chapter 6 takes up that landlord directly.

5.6 *Oliver Twist* (2005): the unhoused child

The orphan is the purest unhoused subject. Oliver passes from the workhouse to an undertaker's shop, where he sleeps among the coffins, dwelling among the dead as Tess's family camps among its tombs, and then to Fagin's den, a counter-household built on stolen property, where the boy himself circulates as property among owners. Dickens's Fagin of 1838 is an antisemitic caricature whose epithets Dickens later softened. Harwood and Polanski's Fagin, played by Ben Kingsley, is aged, frightened and human, and the film closes, as Dickens does near the novel's end, on Oliver's visit to the condemned cell, but turns it from a scene of raving into one of compassion. A Jewish director recasts the caricature: *Besetzung* as recasting.

5.7 *Pirates* (1986) and *Frantic* (1988): furniture and baggage

In *Pirates*, a buccaneer pursues a golden Aztec throne across the sea. Sovereignty becomes furniture, portable and stolen, and the throne rhymes with the wardrobe of 1958: neither can be installed anywhere. In *Frantic*, an American surgeon's wife vanishes in Paris after a luggage mix-up at the airport. Substitution is the plot engine, the foreigner lacks the language, and a courier becomes the surrogate partner. The contraband, a krytron used to trigger nuclear weapons, is hidden in a

souvenir Statue of Liberty, and the climax plays out beside the replica of the statue on the Seine. Liberty appears as a replica, and a hollow one, containing a detonator. Hitchcock's *The Lady Vanishes* (1938) supplies the template.

5.8 History and its exit

Occupation proper confirms the structure. The ghetto, the army archive, the water board, the leasehold and the workhouse are Sadean institutions in Deleuze's sense: they assign roles, requisition spaces and appropriate bodies. One film, however, discloses a difference the rest of the corpus conceals. In *The Pianist* the occupation ends, because it was an occupation, a historical fact rather than an ontological condition. History, unlike ontology, has an exit.



6

Gnostic Landlords

The Occult Films and the Hotel of the World

ARGUMENT

"A *Gnostic cosmos without an alien God, containing only landlords.*"

IN THIS CHAPTER

6.1 The alien God and the archons
6.2 *Rosemary's Baby*: the absentee owner
6.3 *The Ninth Gate* (1999): the book with two authors
6.4 *The Palace* (2023): the hotel of the world
6.5 Gnosis without salvation

6.1 The alien God and the archons

Hans Jonas, Heidegger's student, published *The Gnostic Religion* in 1958, and in the essay "Gnosticism and Modern Nihilism" (1952) he drew the parallel that makes this chapter possible. Ancient Gnosticism held that the cosmos is the work not of the true God, who is alien to it, but of a lesser demiurge whose archons rule the world as a prison. The human being is a stranger thrown into that world, and salvation is knowledge (*gnosis*) of one's alien origin. Jonas argued that existentialism's thrownness and indifferent cosmos amount to a Gnosticism without the alien God.

Polanski's occult films complete the tenurial ontology with the corresponding cosmology. The world is property held by a hostile landlord. The archons are the neighbours, the coven and the board of management, and the human being is a tenant in a world owned by someone else. This is Gnostic tenancy: the alien God is absent, and only the landlord is present.

6.2 *Rosemary's Baby*: the absentee owner

The coven is archontic management. The Castevets and their circle administer the building on behalf of an owner who appears only once, in a dream, as rape, and the lease on Rosemary's body is signed by proxy, by her husband. The Year One is the landlord's new calendar. Classical Gnosticism promised that knowledge would free the stranger, but here knowledge, in the form of Hutch's book and its anagram, arrives only to confirm the occupation. Rosemary's final gesture, rocking the cradle, is the Gnostic nightmare fulfilled: the stranger reconciled to the prison.

6.3 *The Ninth Gate* (1999): the book with two authors

Dean Corso, a mercenary dealer in rare books, is hired by a collector, Boris Balkan, to authenticate his copy of *The Nine Gates of the Kingdom of Shadows*, printed in Venice in 1666 by Aristide Torchia, who was burned by the Inquisition. Three copies survive, in New York, Sintra and Paris. Adapted with John Brownjohn and Enrique Urbizu from Arturo Pérez-Reverte's *El Club Dumas* (1993), shorn of its Dumas plot, the film is the corpus's treatise on authorship as occupation.

Collating the copies, Corso finds that their nine engravings differ subtly, some signed "A.T." and others "L.C.F.": Lucifer. The book has two authors. Either the printer ghostwrote for the devil or the devil for the printer, and authentication becomes the discovery of a second author inside the first. Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–36) located the aura in the original's unique presence, withered by reproduction. In *The Ninth Gate*

the aura resides in no single copy. It is distributed across all three, so the authentic exists only as a collation, assembled from copies and stolen from their owners.

Doubling pervades the film. The twin book restorers who guide Corso are played by a single actor, and the owners of the copies die one by one. Balkan, convinced that he owns the gate, performs the ritual and immolates himself, because one of his nine plates is a forgery: the proprietor burns. Corso, guided by an enigmatic young woman who may be guardian or demon, recovers the authentic plate and walks through a castle gate into white light, toward ascension or damnation, the film does not say.

Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915) tells of a man from the country who waits his whole life before a door guarded by a doorkeeper, only to learn at the end that the door was meant for him alone and is now being shut. *The Ninth Gate* inverts the parable. The door meant only for Corso, the one character who never claimed to own anything, opens; the tenant who never mistook the book for property passes, while the proprietor burns. Borges's "The Library of Babel" (1941) and "The Book of Sand" (1975), and Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980), with its poisoned book, and *Foucault's Pendulum* (1988), in which an invented occult Plan becomes real, form the film's bibliographic constellation: knowledge as property, lethal to those who would own it.

6.4 *The Palace* (2023): the hotel of the world

Co-written with Jerzy Skolimowski and Ewa Piaskowska, *The Palace* is set in a grand hotel in Gstaad on New Year's Eve 1999, as a punctilious manager and his staff attempt to service the millennial revels of a clientele of grotesquely wealthy guests. It was poorly received at Venice.

Siegfried Kracauer's essay "The Hotel Lobby," written in the early 1920s as part of his study of the detective novel, describes the lobby as the negative image of the church: a congregation without God, whose members meet as incognito guests in a space of pure relation without community. Vicki Baum's *Menschen im Hotel* (1929) and its film version, *Grand Hotel* (1932), made the hotel the modern world's allegory, a place of arrivals and departures in which nothing happens. Kubrick's Overlook supplied the caretaker who has always been the caretaker.

In the hotel the tenurial ontology reaches its terminal form. Everyone is a guest; the owner is invisible; the manager is a demiurge serving an absent proprietor; and time itself is let by the night. The date carries a historical rhyme, since 31 December 1999 was also the night on which Boris Yeltsin's resignation passed Russian power to Vladimir Putin, a succession presented as a new beginning. Gstaad, moreover, is the town where the director lives, where he was held under house arrest in 2009–10 pending extradition, and where two of the women who have

accused him say he raped them at his chalet, in 1972 and 1975, allegations he denies. The late film's hotel is the address not of an exile but of a man who has lived beyond the reach of an American sentence since 1978. Even its critical failure is legible: a loop with no exit exhausts itself as farce.

6.5 Gnosis without salvation

In classical Gnosticism knowledge of one's alien origin liberates. In Polanski knowledge (Hutch's book, the engravings, the acrostic of *The Ghost Writer*) never liberates. It confirms the occupation, and the single ambiguous exception, Corso's passage through the gate, is granted to the one character who never pursued ownership. The corpus thus arrives at a metaphysical cul-de-sac: a Gnostic cosmos without an alien God, containing only landlords. The final chapter asks whether the corpus itself contains an exit.



7

Toward a Tenurial Ontology

ARGUMENT

"Responsibility for one's own acts is the one tenancy that cannot be sublet."

IN THIS CHAPTER

7.1 Seven propositions
7.2 The tenurial fantastic
7.3 Possessive individualism and its negative
7.4 Two temporalities of tenure
7.5 The crypt
7.6 *Fehlbesetzung*, again
7.7 Conclusion: the door marked *besetzt*

7.1 Seven propositions

The preceding chapters can now be formalised.

I **Every occupancy is a succession.** There is no first tenant. Every room, role and object of desire has been held before, by Mrs. Gardenia, Simone Choule, McAra, Sandherr, the dead of the Mar Vista rest home. Origin is replaced by predecessor.

II **The predecessor persists as trace, not heritage.** Heritage is transmitted with its meaning; the trace, in Benjamin's sense, persists without it, as an instruction no one issued: the tooth, the note, the programmed route, the archive of forgeries. Derrida's hauntology, in *Specters of Marx* (1993), names the ontology of what is neither present nor absent.

III **The neighbour is sovereign.** Sovereignty is exercised not by the state in its majesty but by the adjacent (the concierge, the coven, the co-op board, the neighbour who screams), who decides on the exception in Schmitt's sense and reduces the tenant to the bare occupancy that Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) calls bare life.

IV **Casting precedes existence.** One is assigned a part before one exists as the one who plays it, as Mauss, Gombrowicz and Althusser variously show. The self is the residue of its roles.

V **Cathexis is a lease.** Desire invests its objects on revocable terms and by contract, in Deleuze's sense, and the investment may be administered by an occupier, from Witkacy's pill to the coven's drugged dessert. No object is owned; every attachment has a term.

VI **Death is not one's ownmost.** Against Heidegger, the tenant dies a predecessor's death, as Trelkovsky and the Ghost do, or has death assigned as a role, as with Dreyfus's degradation, a civil death, and Tess, taken from the altar stone to be hanged. Even finitude is sublet.

VII **Every exit is a re-entry.** The loop is the corpus's signature form, from the idling car of *Knife in the Water* to the plaster cast of *The Tenant*. Freud's repetition compulsion, in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), is its psychic law; the French *tacite reconduction*, the automatic renewal of a lease no one terminates, is its juridical name.

7.2

The tenurial fantastic

Todorov defined the fantastic as hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation. Darko Suvin's *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction* (1979) defined science fiction as the literature of cognitive estrangement organised around a *novum*, a new thing validated by cognitive logic. Polanski's cinema produces estrangement without a novum. Where it admits the supernatural, in *Rosemary's Baby* and *The Ninth Gate*, it withholds or suspends it; where it does not, in *Repulsion* and *The Tenant*, estrangement arises from the already-occupied rather than the new. This is a *post-occupational fantastic*, in which the replacement has always already happened.

The distinction clarifies the corpus's place in the speculative tradition. In most speculative fiction the replacement of persons is an event. The pods of Jack Finney's *The Body Snatchers* (1955) arrive, and the wives of Levin's *The Stepford Wives* (1972) are manufactured. In Polanski replacement is a precondition. The comparanda array themselves along this axis:

- **Kafka** gives tenancy as fate: the lodgers of *The Metamorphosis*, the noise of "The Burrow," the door of "Before the Law."
- **Bulgakov** gives the devil as the tenant who evicts, in *The Master and Margarita*'s bad apartment.
- **Gilman** gives escape as substitution, in the woman freed from behind "The Yellow Wallpaper."
- **Lem** gives, in *Solaris* (1961), the guests: replicas of the dead who occupy the living's quarters, whom the living cannot evict, and who cannot bear to be shut out, as Harey tears through a metal door to follow Kelvin.
- **Abe** gives, in *The Woman in the Dunes* (1962), tenancy accepted as vocation.
- **Ballard** gives, in *High-Rise* (1975), the building as state of nature.
- **Dick** gives occupied America in *The Man in the High Castle* (1962) and, in *Time Out of Joint* (1959), a man living in a town built as a set to keep him at work: the surrogate geography of the Cold War.
- **Perec** gives, in *W* (1975), the island that becomes a camp.
- **Ishiguro** gives, in *Never Let Me Go* (2005), cloned donors whose organs are leased from birth and who pursue a rumoured "deferral," a lease extension on life granted to those who can prove love. It is the tenurial ontology's most tender speculative statement.
- **Peele** gives, in *Get Out* (2017), the body occupied by another's consciousness, and the Sunken Place as a view of one's own life from a distant rear window.

Speculative fiction generally imagines the occupation of a self that was first free. Polanski begins after the occupation and denies the prior freedom.

7.3 Possessive individualism and its negative

C.B. Macpherson described the possessive individual as the proprietor of his own person and capacities, owing nothing to society for them, so that freedom is self-ownership. Polanski's corpus is that figure's photographic negative: no one owns their person, their role or their desire.

The danger is obvious. A tenurial ontology can be exculpatory: if no one owns their acts, no one answers for them, and the corpus's own signatory has shown how a doctrine of the occupied self can be bent into a plea. The answer is *tenurial responsibility*. Precisely because the tenant owns nothing, he answers to predecessor and successor alike. Levinas's hostage is responsible before any choice. Hans Jonas, the same thinker who diagnosed Gnostic alienation, later founded in *The Imperative of Responsibility* (1979) an ethics of custodianship, which obliges the living to act so that their effects remain compatible with the permanence of genuine human life on earth. The Gnostic tenant owes nothing to a landlord he despises. The Jonasian tenant owes much to successors he will never meet.

The oldest statement of tenurial ontology is theological, and it is not Gnostic. "The land shall not be sold for ever: for the land is mine; for ye are strangers and sojourners with me" (Leviticus 25:23). Here the landlord is just, the lease has a term, and restitution is written into the calendar. Every fiftieth year is a Jubilee, in which liberty is proclaimed throughout the land and each returns to his possession (Leviticus 25:10), the verse inscribed on the Liberty Bell. *Frantic*'s hollow Statue of Liberty, with a detonator inside, is liberty without the Jubilee.

7.4 Two temporalities of tenure

The corpus therefore knows two temporalities. The first is tacit renewal: the lease renews itself because no one gives notice. It governs *Knife in the Water*, *Cul-de-sac*, *The Fearless Vampire Killers*, *Rosemary's Baby*, *Macbeth*, *Chinatown*, *The Tenant*, *Bitter Moon*, *The Ghost Writer* and *The Palace*. The second is the Jubilee: the lease expires, and the dispossessed returns to his place. It occurs exactly once, when Szpilman, after the war, sits again at the piano of Polish Radio and plays the nocturne the bombs interrupted in 1939. Even *J'accuse*, which restores Dreyfus's honour, withholds it, in Picquart's refusal of the lost years.

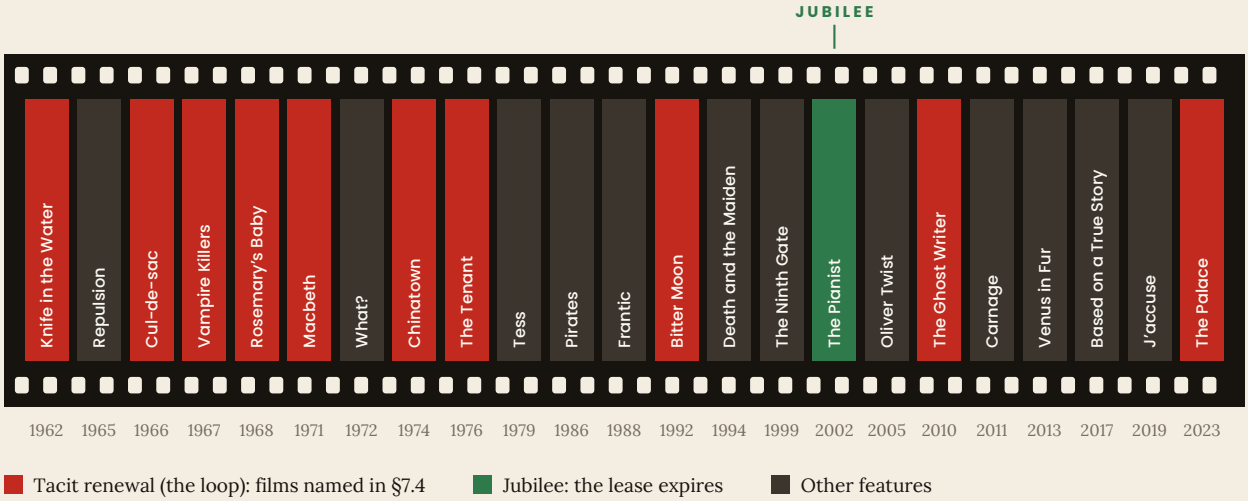


Fig. 2. *The twenty-three features, 1962–2023, read as a single strip of film. Red frames are the films §7.4 assigns to tacit renewal; the single green frame is the corpus's only Jubilee.*

The question is why the Jubilee occurs only once. The answer is that only in *The Pianist* is the occupation named as history.

7.5 The crypt

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguishes two responses to loss. In mourning, libido is withdrawn from the lost object piece by piece until the ego is free again. In melancholia, the ego identifies with the lost object, so that, in Freud's image, the object's shadow falls upon the ego. Trelkovsky's becoming-Simone is the exact figure of melancholic identification: the tenant incorporates the predecessor. In the terms of this dissertation, mourning withdraws the cathexis and terminates the lease, while melancholia renews it tacitly, inside the ego.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok, in the essays collected in *The Shell and the Kernel* (1987), sharpen the distinction into one between introjection, the assimilation of loss, and incorporation, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and entombing it in an intrapsychic crypt. Abraham's "Notes on the Phantom" (1975) describes an unspoken secret of a previous generation that lodges in a descendant and speaks through him. *The Wolf Man's Magic Word* (1976) names cryptonymy, words that hide other words.

Polanski's corpus is a cryptonymic archive: the anagram of *Rosemary's Baby*, the acrostic of *The Ghost Writer*, the double signature of *The Ninth Gate*, the contested hand of the *bordereau*, the hieroglyphs of Simone's lavatory. The tooth in the wall is a crypt in the most literal sense, a fragment of the lost entombed in the dwelling, and the predecessor-trace is the phantom. The loop of tacit renewal is thus the form of a history not yet mourned, and the tenurial ontology is melancholia raised to metaphysics. *The Pianist*, which names the history

and lets the lost be lost, is the corpus's work of mourning. It converts incorporation into introjection, and so the lease can expire.

The dissertation's central conclusion follows. The tenurial ontology is true as a description of the occupied and false as a metaphysics. Read whole, Polanski's cinema performs its own critique: it constructs an ontology of occupation across four decades, then, in a single film, reveals that ontology to be the shape of an unmourned history.

7.6 *Fehlbesetzung*, again

The same conclusion governs the signatory. The claim to own the role of the persecuted, examined in section 5.3, is a melancholic incorporation of another's history as one's own: a crypt built for an alibi. The corpus's logic refuses it. In these films suffering, like everything else, is held on lease, and responsibility for one's own acts is the one tenancy that cannot be sublet.

7.7 Conclusion: the door marked *besetzt*

The sign on the lavatory door reads *besetzt*. It is the humblest emblem of the corpus: a notice that someone is inside, that the room is held, that one must wait. Polanski's cinema is written almost entirely on this face of the sign, in rooms always taken, roles always cast, desires always on loan.

The sign has a second face. "Occupied" is a temporary state, and the same bolt that turns the sign to *besetzt* turns it back to *frei*. Once in the corpus the sign turns. A pianist sits at the instrument from which the war drove him and plays again the nocturne the bombs interrupted. The room is his again, not because he owns it, but because the occupation is over. A tenurial ontology cannot promise ownership. What it can promise, when history is named and mourned rather than entombed, is vacancy: the possibility that a lease may end, and that what was interrupted may be resumed.

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Keywords

Roman Polanski / *Besetzung* / tenurial ontology / occupation / casting / cathexis / tenancy / succession / predecessor-trace / the uncanny / Apartment Trilogy / hostipitality / hospitality / Polish absurd / Theatre of the Absurd / Witold Gombrowicz / Jan Kott / Heidegger / dwelling / Walter Benjamin / trace / Jacques Derrida / hauntology / Emmanuel Levinas / substitution / Gilles Deleuze / masochism / contract / interpellation / performativity / Penthean cycle / *Fehlbesetzung* / surrogate geography / lipogram / Georges Perec / Holocaust representation / *The Pianist* / Dreyfus Affair / Gnosticism / Hans Jonas / mourning and melancholia / crypt / cryptonymy / Abraham and Torok / the fantastic / novum / speculative fiction / possessive individualism / Jubilee / tacit renewal / film-philosophy



“A tenurial ontology cannot promise ownership. What it can promise, when history is named and mourned rather than entombed, is vacancy: the possibility that a lease may end, and that what was interrupted may be resumed.”